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How to Tame a Wild Mother Tongue: A Comparison in Language Dynamics

In the articles “How to Tame a Wild Tongue” by Gloria Amzaldúa and “Mother Tongue” by Amy Tan, the authors show how minority and immigrant communities strive and struggle with their identity while integrating within the dominant English language. Tan presents an anecdotal piece based on her mother and their joint hardship being immigrants, while Amzaldúa outlines her Chicano identity and its history and conflicted views due to the culture’s mixed nature. These struggles are displayed in similar ways throughout both articles nevertheless keeping a different tone and rhetoric to appeal towards the same point, how language dynamics could suppress or contribute to the struggle of immigrant and minority communities.

In *Mother Tongue* Tan claims that because her mother is an immigrant and communicates relatively poorly in English she is discounted by many people in the world due to these communication issues, in one example she is unable to convey to a doctor the importance of a medical exam to her personally (Tan). The fact of being seen as less of a person by not being willing or unable to subjugate yourself to the language of the majority. This is also seen in Amzaldúa’s piece, “How to Tame a Wild Tongue”, although its theme more violent through its abrasive anecdotes, it is just as emotional; here she states that she can often face ridicule and being called a traitor just for speaking the Chicano Spanish dialect (Amzaldúa 358). Both works highlight the consequences of speaking a language or dialect outside of the norm, leading to

personal and social strife, the cases present a situation known too well by immigrants in the United States and elsewhere needing a large amount of mental fortitude for many to assimilate into a language previously unknown.

The display of such struggle is differentiated between the pieces, even more so when the authors discuss how the struggle could be overcome. In Amzaldúa's work she takes an anti-colonialist and socialist viewpoint towards class struggle, using phrases like "Wild tongues can't be tamed… only cut out" (Amzaldúa 358). And adding an entire phrase on "Linguistic Terrorism" (Amzaldúa 361). These help to convey the point of Amzaldúa however it heavily contrasts with Tan's essay on a different type of struggle. Tan outlines a simpler, everyday struggle of adapting your language use between different identities and communities. To fix this issue of code switching Tan proposes that the easiest way to bridge these communities is by encouraging use of simpler English, , with the audience of immigrants in mind "…preserving the essence…" (Tan). Of both communities. This recognition and understanding of the "broken" English used by immigrants would not only preserve a culture but would also lessen the struggle faced by non-English speakers.

Personally, I can relate to both stories, like Tan I watched my parents especially suffer from learning English; and like Amzaldúa I had to integrate myself into a new culture which is slowly erasing my old one. Culture plays the largest portion in language dynamics, Amzaldúa specifically outlines identity's portion in her Chicano culture's struggle stating that she feels as if she is a part "… of two cultures with various degrees of Mexicanness or Angloness" (Amzaldúa 365). She follows up on this split identity by saying that this has caused her to internalize border conflict, the clash between her two parts. This issue of identity is more than prevalent in my personal life, for example, if someone asks me "Where are you from?" I don't know whether I

should reply with my Hungarian cultural identity or the dominant English language which essentially commandeers my self-expression. Tan also realizes something similar, she tells us about how her mother's lacking English ability led her to encounter troubles learning English as well, leaving her frustrated unable to express herself well enough, showed by her poor English scores in school (Tan).

In all, both Gloria Amzaldúa in "How to Tame a Wild Tongue" and Amy Tan in *Mother Tongue* show the internal and external struggle of minority and immigrant cultures on the backdrop of a prominent language. By using various themes throughout both works the authors highlight their experiences mostly relating towards their identities and how that effects their everyday life and their own culture. These prevailing themes outline issues with identity and the dominant English language, bringing awareness to cultural suppression.

Works Cited:

Amzaldúa, Gloria. "How to Tame a Wild Tongue." *Available Means: An Anthology of Women'S Rhetoric(s)*. Ed. Joy Ritchie and Kate Ronald. University of Pittsburgh Press, 2001. 356-365. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt5hjqnj>.

Tan, Amy. *Mother Tongue*. 1990.